FOR ALMOST SIX DECADES IN Mumbai, the slogan, *'Avaaz kunacha?* (Whose writ runs here?)' has been met with a resounding reply—*'Shiv Sena-cha* (the Shiv Sena's)'—signifying the party's dominance over the country's financial capital and swathes of Maharashtra. This assembly election will answer a more pointed question—which Shiv Sena?

In June 2022, Eknath Shinde and his 39 legislators split the parent party and toppled the Uddhav Thackeray-led Maha Vikas Aghadi (MVA) regime to form a government in alliance with the BJP. The subsequent legal battle saw the Shiv Sena name and bow-and-arrow symbol being handed over to Shinde. However, the Thackeray brand, seen as synonymous with the party's identity, stayed with the Shiv Sena (Uddhav Balasaheb Thackeray).

The Lok Sabha election was supposed to settle the question of who ran the 'real Shiv Sena', but with SS(UBT) getting nine seats and Shinde's Sena seven, it was a draw of sorts. A key point: the Thackeray Sena saw its core Marathi vote split. The shortfall was made good, thanks to allies Congress and the Nationalist Congress Party (NCP), by the near-total transfer of Muslim votes to it, especially in Mumbai—a far cry from the days of late party supremo Bal Thackeray, given his aggressive Hindutva and the Sena's many frictions with the minority community.

Uddhav's loyalists claim Shinde's "*gaddari* (treachery)" and the resultant sympathy wave will lead its core Marathi *manoos* voters to coalesce around the residual party. Shinde supporters, in turn, insist that Uddhav's compact with the Sena's erstwhile foes dilutes his Hindutva credentials. They also have the BJP's base to fall back on, even if that can prove dicey. That existential iffiness leads back to an essential feature of Shinde's Sena: it's more of a loose conglomeration of legislators and leaders than a political organisation. Shinde being the CM is the glue that holds them together, hence losing the chair may cloud not just his future but also of his party.

Questions of political survival also apply to Uddhav, in a way that may mark a moment of evolution for India's family-run parties. For, at stake here is the legacy of the late Bal Thackeray, which still holds a talismanic appeal with the party faithful. Will that suffice to extend the old Sena's control over Mumbai and the larger Mumbai Metropolitan Region (MMR)? Especially with the subtle departures Uddhav has made vis-a-vis its underlying politics?

Graphic by TANMOY CHAKRABORTY

SENA VS SENA

The Sena wars will see some heavyweight contenders from both factions going toe to toe this election

94 SHIV SENA (UBT) CANDIDATES

85 SHIV SENA CANDIDATES

DIRECT FIGHT IN 47 SEATS

GRUDGE FIGHTS

WORLI



AADITYA THACKERAY
SS(UBT)

Vs



MILIND DEORA
Shiv Sena

The Thackeray scion faces the ex-Congress leader who switched camps in January. Worry factor: SS(UBT) had very small lead in the segment in LS poll

KOPRI PACHPAKHADI



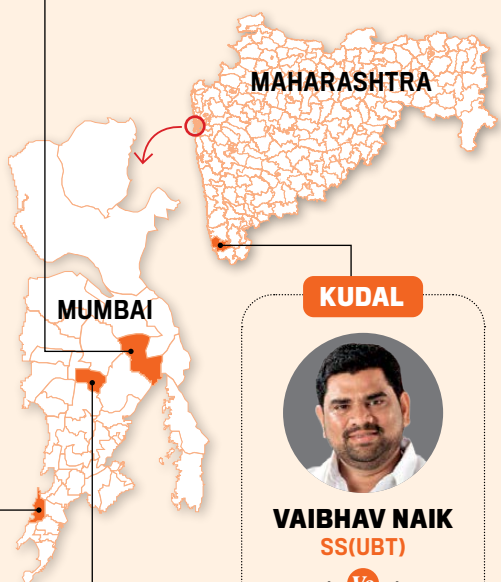
KEDAR DIGHE
SS(UBT)

Vs



EKNATH SHINDE
Shiv Sena

Shinde finds himself up against his mentor and late Thane strongman Anand Dighe's nephew, Kedar



KUDAL

VAIBHAV NAIK
SS(UBT)

Vs



NILESH RANE
Shiv Sena

Naik is also on a hat-trick. He had beaten Nilesh's father, ex-CM Narayan Rane, in 2014. Can the son do better?

DINDOSHI



SUNIL PRABHU
SS(UBT)

Vs



SANJAY NIRUPAM
Shiv Sena

Prabhu is looking to make it a hat-trick of victories here, while maverick Nirupam comes full circle with return to Sena